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What is Our True Purpose in Life?

My name is Serena—yes, Serena. I am a fifteen-year-old who grew up in a Christian family. My parents taught me about Christianity from a young age, and my father was once a spiritual leader in the church, though he has since retired from his ministry duties. I have two siblings—a brother and a sister. Since childhood, we have learned a great deal about God's Word, including lessons on sin and various stories from the Bible. You could say I was a "good" child back then. I was afraid of committing sin; even saying the word "crazy" felt like a major transgression to me when I was little. I made a conscious effort to avoid the sins my parents had warned me about.

Every Sunday, I would go to church to worship, listen to God's Word, and praise His name. I always paid close attention to my Sunday school teacher as they explained the Scriptures. I was also very active in church activities, I even participated in—and won—competitions held between my church and others, such as Bible quiz contests. Because of this active involvement, I became increasingly visible to others. I became well-known not only in my own church, but also in other churches as well.

As people began to notice me, they assumed I was a deeply spiritual child, they developed high expectations for me, hoping my life would mirror that of my older siblings, who were known for their piety and spirituality. At first, I was happy to be gaining

recognition, but the expectations of others forced me to uphold both my own reputation and that of my family. Gradually, I grew weary of those expectations, the fake smile I showed week after week began to fade, much like the faith I was starting to doubt.

On May 3rd, I watched a video clip titled "Daily Sacrifice," which told the story of someone who decided to stop making daily sacrifices solely to meet the expectations of others. As I watched it, I felt a personal connection to the story and decided I wanted to be like the person in it. I began to stop caring about others, ignoring them as if they were strangers to me. However, instead of just avoiding people, I also began to avoid God, I stopped attending church, I no longer read the Bible, and I skipped every Gospel video that appeared in my feed. I feel as though I have strayed from His path, yet at least I am living freely, without the rules of the Bible weighing on my mind.

I felt happy experiencing the life I wanted to lead without the burden of meeting others' expectations, yet that joy was short-lived. After having fun with my friends, I returned home exhausted. I lay down on my soft bed and drifted into thought for a moment, reflecting on the things that happened in my life. Suddenly, I remembered the days when I was deeply involved in church activities, diligently reading the Bible, and my good commingling. Compared to my life now, my life is very different from before. I began to feel guilty, anxious, and worried about my behavior. I wondered, "Will God still forgive me after all the sins I've committed?" I knew that God would forgive me, but somehow I doubted my faith.

I didn't want to think about it any longer. I took a deep breath and got ready for bed. Hoping that when I woke up the next day, I would have found the answer. Ten minutes passed, and I still couldn't fall asleep. Fifteen minutes. Twenty minutes. Even by the 30th minute, I couldn't fall asleep. Usually, just closing my eyes for a moment would do the trick. But tonight, it felt like something was holding me back. I felt frustrated, because I wanted to sleep but couldn't.

I slowly sat up and accidentally glanced at the Bible on my desk. It started to remind me of the times when I used to read the Bible every night before sleep. I felt the presence of the Holy Spirit in my heart, as if urging me to pick up the Bible and read it. So, I walked to my desk and took my Bible to my bed. "Okay, maybe one verse only for tonight," said I as I started to open the Bible.

I still have the list of the Bible verses on a paper that I made for me to face any situation in my life, so I chose random verses from those. From 15 verses, I randomly chose 2 Corinthians 5:7, it says, "For we walk by faith and not by sight." This verse made me realize that I have lost my faith now, I have been walking by sight for nowadays. I start to feel guilty again for the sins I have done. But then I remember, I don't need to feel guilty! All I need to do is change for it is not late for me to change and go back to His path. I know that it might not be easy to be the person you used to be, but I trust in Him and myself that I can change.

So the next day, I began to read the Bible everyday, not one verse only, but one whole chapter of the Proverbs. It really helped me in regaining my faith! I became the person that God wants me to be. I start to come to the church again, follow the activities, and listen to God's Words attentively. I'm so grateful for the life I'm living now, it's all because of the Holy Spirit who helped me face all of the evil temptation! And so yeah, that was the story of my life when I slowly lost my faith in God. But I found the way back through the Holy Spirit! The Holy Spirit brings me a new life and cleanses my spirit, giving me a fresh start in my walk with God, as it says in Titus 3:5, "He saved us, not because of righteous things we had done, but because of his mercy. He saved us through the washing of rebirth and renewal by the Holy Spirit."